FINISH THE IDIOM

160 ENGLISH IDIOMS
MEANING AND EXAMPLE

IDIOMS 129

1 **Actions speak louder than words**
What you do matters more than what you say.
He promises a lot, but actions speak louder than words.

2 **Back to square one**
Back to the beginning after a failure.
The client rejected the design, so it's back to square one.

3 **The ball is in your court**
It is your decision now.
I've made my offer, so the ball is in your court.

4 **A ballpark figure**
A rough estimate, usually of a number or a cost.
At a ballpark figure, about three thousand.

5 **Bark up the wrong tree**
Follow completely the wrong idea.
If you think I took it, you're barking up the wrong tree.

6 **Be snowed under**
Have far too much work.
She's snowed under with marking.

7 **Be up in the air**
Still uncertain, not decided.
The date is up in the air until he answers.

8 **Beat around the bush**
Avoid saying what you really mean.
Stop beating around the bush and tell me the price.

9 **The bee's knees**
The very best thing there is.
She thinks that cafe is the bee's knees.

10 **Beggars can't be choosers**
If you have no choice, you take what you are given.
It's a tiny flat, but beggars can't be choosers.

11 **Bend over backwards**
Try extremely hard to help someone.
She bent over backwards to get us a table.

12 **The best of both worlds**
A situation where you get the advantages of two things.
Working two days at home is the best of both worlds.

13 **Better late than never**
Doing something late is better than not doing it.
He apologised after a year, but better late than never.

14 **Better safe than sorry**
It is wiser to be careful than to take a risk.
Take an umbrella, better safe than sorry.

15 **Bite the bullet**
Accept something unpleasant and get on with it.
We bit the bullet and told him the truth.

16 **A blessing in disguise**
Something that seems bad at first but turns out to be good.
Losing that job was a blessing in disguise.

17 **The bottom line**
The one fact that matters once everything else is stripped away.
The bottom line is that nobody wants to pay for it.

18 **Break a leg**
Good luck, said to a performer.
Break a leg at the audition.

19 **A bucket list**
The things you want to do before you die.
Iceland is right at the top of my bucket list.

20 **Burn the midnight oil**
Work very late into the night.
I burned the midnight oil to finish the report.

21 **Burn your bridges**
Damage a relationship so badly that you cannot go back.
He burnt his bridges on the way out of that company.

22 **Butterflies in your stomach**
Nervous excitement before something.
I had butterflies in my stomach before the speech.

23 **Call it a day**
Stop working on something for now.
At six o'clock we called it a day.

24 **Cost an arm and a leg**
Be very expensive.
Parking at the airport costs an arm and a leg.

25 **A couch potato**
Someone who sits in front of the TV all day.
He's a couch potato at the weekend.

26 **Cut corners**
Do something cheaply or quickly and badly.
Don't cut corners on the safety checks.

27 **Cut to the chase**
Get to the important part.
Let's cut to the chase, how much do you want?

28 **A dead-end job**
A job with no chance of progress.
She left a dead-end job to retrain as a nurse.

29 **A deep dive**
A detailed examination of something.
She did a deep dive into why the costs went up.

30 **The devil is in the detail**
The small details are where the real problems are.
The contract looks fine, but the devil is in the detail.

31 **Don't count your chickens before they hatch**
Don't rely on something good until it has actually happened.
You haven't signed yet, so don't count your chickens.

32 **Don't put all your eggs in one basket**
Don't risk everything on one plan.
Apply to three universities, don't put all your eggs in one basket.

33 **A double-edged sword**
Something with a good side and a bad side.
Working from home is a double-edged sword.

34 **Drop the ball**
Fail to do something you were responsible for.
I dropped the ball on the invoices last month.

35 **The early bird catches the worm**
The person who acts first gets the advantage.
Tickets go fast, so the early bird catches the worm.

36 **Easier said than done**
It sounds simple but it is hard in practice.
Just stop worrying? Easier said than done.

37 **The elephant in the room**
An obvious problem that nobody wants to talk about.
Nobody mentioned the money, the elephant in the room.

38 **Every cloud has a silver lining**
Every bad situation has something good in it.
The flight was cancelled, but every cloud has a silver lining, we got a free hotel.

39 **A game changer**
Something that changes a situation completely.
The new software has been a game changer for the team.

40 **Get cold feet**
Become too nervous to do something you planned.
I got cold feet and cancelled the interview.

41 **Get the hang of something**
Learn how to do something after a bit of practice.
She got the hang of the software in a day.

42 **Get your act together**
Start organising yourself and behaving properly.
If he doesn't get his act together, he'll fail.

43 **Give someone the cold shoulder**
Deliberately ignore someone you know.
I said hello and got the cold shoulder.

44 **The glass ceiling**
The invisible barrier that stops women reaching the top jobs.
They talk about diversity, but the glass ceiling is still there.

45 **Go bananas**
Get wildly excited or very angry.
My dad went bananas when he saw the bill.

46 **Go down a rabbit hole**
Get lost in something complicated for a long time.
I went down a rabbit hole reading about volcanoes.

47 **Go pear-shaped**
Go badly wrong.
The whole trip went pear-shaped on day two.

48 **Go viral**
Spread very quickly online.
The clip went viral and the shop sold out.

49 **Go with the flow**
Accept the situation and do what others are doing.
There's no plan tonight, we'll just go with the flow.

50 **The grass is always greener on the other side**
Other people's situations always look better than yours.
She misses her old job, but the grass is always greener.

51 **A grey area**
A situation where the rules are not clear.
Working from another country is a grey area.

52 **Have a chip on your shoulder**
Stay angry about something unfair that happened to you.
He's had a chip on his shoulder since they passed him over.

53 **Have a lot on your plate**
Have a lot of work or problems to deal with.
He has a lot on his plate this month.

54 **Have bigger fish to fry**
Have more important things to deal with.
He won't mind, he's got bigger fish to fry.

55 **Have second thoughts**
Start to doubt a decision you made.
I'm having second thoughts about the flat.

56 **Have the bandwidth**
Have the time and energy to take something on.
I'd love to help, but I don't have the bandwidth until June.

57 **Have your head in the clouds**
Dreaming instead of dealing with real life.
He's lovely, but his head is always in the clouds.

58 **Hit the ground running**
Start something fast and well.
She hit the ground running in the new job.

59 **Hit the nail on the head**
Say exactly the right thing about a problem.
You've hit the nail on the head, it's a money problem.

60 **Hit the sack**
Go to bed.
Hit the sack early, we leave at six.

61 **In the long run**
Over a long period of time in the future.
In the long run, honesty is cheaper.

62 **In two minds**
Undecided about something.
She's in two minds about selling the flat.

63 **It takes two to tango**
Both people are responsible, not just one.
Don't blame her alone, it takes two to tango.

64 **Jump on the bandwagon**
Join something only because it has become popular.
Everyone jumped on the padel bandwagon last year.

65 **Keep someone in the loop**
Keep someone informed about what is happening.
She was good at keeping everyone in the loop.

66 **Keep your head above water**
Just manage to cope, usually with money or work.
Since the rent went up we have barely kept our heads above water.

67 **Kick the bucket**
Die, or stop working, said jokingly.
My phone kicked the bucket last night.

68 **The last straw**
The final small thing you can take.
The broken promise was the last straw for her.

69 **Let the cat out of the bag**
Give away a secret by accident.
He let the cat out of the bag about the party.

70 **Low-hanging fruit**
The easiest useful thing to do first.
Start with the low-hanging fruit and show a quick result.

71 **Make ends meet**
Earn just enough money to pay for what you need.
With two kids, they're struggling to make ends meet.

72 **Miss the boat**
Lose a chance because you were too slow.
They missed the boat on the cheap tickets.

73 **Move the goalposts**
Change the rules or the target after the work has started.
Every time we finish something, they move the goalposts.

74 **Move the needle**
Make a noticeable difference to a result.
Nothing we tried moved the needle on sales.

75 **Nine to five**
The standard working day, and the routine that comes with it.
I'm not built for a nine-to-five.

76 **No pain, no gain**
You have to suffer a little to get results.
My legs are killing me, but no pain, no gain.

77 **Not my cup of tea**
Not something you enjoy.
Horror films are not my cup of tea.

78 **Not the sharpest tool in the shed**
Not very clever, said kindly.
Lovely lad, just not the sharpest tool in the shed.

79 **Off the top of my head**
Without checking or thinking carefully.
Off the top of my head, I'd say about forty people came.

80 **On the back burner**
Left aside to deal with later.
We've put the move on the back burner for now.

81 **On the fence**
Unable to decide between two sides.
Half the class is on the fence about the trip.

82 **On the same page**
In agreement, understanding things the same way.
The two teams were finally on the same page.

83 **On the tip of my tongue**
You almost remember a word but can't quite say it.
The word was on the tip of her tongue all evening.

84 **On thin ice**
In a risky position where one more mistake brings trouble.
He has been on thin ice since the complaint.

85 **Once in a blue moon**
Very rarely.
He cooks once in a blue moon, and then it is beans on toast.

86 **Out of sight, out of mind**
You forget about things you cannot see.
Out of sight, out of mind works for my phone too.

87 **Out of the blue**
Suddenly and unexpectedly.
The email arrived completely out of the blue.

88 **Over the moon**
Absolutely delighted.
She was over the moon with the result.

89 **A pain in the neck**
Something or someone annoying.
Parking round here is a pain in the neck.

90 **A piece of cake**
Very easy.
For her, parallel parking is a piece of cake.

91 **Play it by ear**
Decide as you go, without a fixed plan.
Let's play it by ear and see who turns up.

92 **Practice makes perfect**
You improve at something by doing it repeatedly.
Keep speaking every day, practice makes perfect.

93 **Pull out all the stops**
Make every possible effort.
They pulled out all the stops for the wedding.

94 **Pull someone's leg**
Joke with someone by telling them something untrue.
She was pulling your leg about the fine.

95 **Put your foot in it**
Say something embarrassing or tactless by accident.
I asked about his wife, then really put my foot in it.

96 **Raining cats and dogs**
Raining extremely hard.
Take a coat, it's raining cats and dogs.

97 **The rat race**
The exhausting competition of ordinary working life.
He got out of the rat race at forty.

98 **A reality check**
A moment that forces you to see how things really are.
Seeing the real prices was a reality check.

99 **A red flag**
A clear warning sign about a person or a situation.
Asking for the money upfront was a red flag.

100 **A red herring**
A detail that leads you away from the truth.
That whole detail was a red herring.

101 **Red tape**
Official rules and paperwork that slow everything down.
There's so much red tape involved in registering a company.

102 **Ring a bell**
Sound familiar.
Does the title ring a bell?

103 **Saved by the bell**
Rescued at the very last second.
The phone rang and I was saved by the bell.

104 **A slippery slope**
A small bad step that leads to much worse things.
Lending him money is a slippery slope.

105 **Spill the beans**
Tell a secret.
He spilled the beans about the surprise.

106 **Steal someone's thunder**
Take the attention that should have been theirs.
She announced it first and stole his thunder.

107 **A steep learning curve**
A situation where you have to learn a great deal very quickly.
Moving into management was a steep learning curve.

108 **Stick to your guns**
Refuse to change your opinion or decision.
They pushed him hard, but he stuck to his guns.

109 **A storm in a teacup**
A lot of fuss about something unimportant.
The whole argument was a storm in a teacup.

110 **Take a rain check**
Say no for now but yes another time.
I'll take a rain check on dinner, I'm exhausted.

111 **Take it with a pinch of salt**
Don't believe it completely.
He exaggerates, so take it with a pinch of salt.

112 **There's no use crying over spilt milk**
There is no point being upset about something you can't change.
The car's sold now, no use crying over spilt milk.

113 **Think outside the box**
Think in a new and original way.
They want someone who can think outside the box.

114 **Through thick and thin**
In good times and bad.
They have stayed together through thick and thin.

115 **Throw in the towel**
Give up.
Don't throw in the towel this close to the end.

116 **Throw someone under the bus**
Blame someone else to save yourself.
He threw his own team under the bus in the meeting.

117 **Tick all the boxes**
Meet every requirement.
On paper he ticks all the boxes.

118 **The tip of the iceberg**
The small visible part of a much bigger problem.
Those complaints are just the tip of the iceberg.

119 **Touch base**
Make brief contact to check how things are going.
Let's touch base on Monday before the client call.

120 **Touch wood**
Said to avoid bad luck after talking about good luck.
Touch wood, the car has never let me down.

121 **Under the weather**
Slightly ill.
I'm a little under the weather today.

122 **A vicious circle**
A situation where each problem makes the next one worse.
Debt and overtime turned into a vicious circle.

123 **A wake-up call**
A shock that makes you change how you live or work.
The failed inspection was a wake-up call for the team.

124 **When in Rome, do as the Romans do**
Follow the local customs when you are somewhere new.
They eat at ten here, so when in Rome, do as the Romans do.

125 **When it rains, it pours**
Bad things tend to happen all at once.
The boiler broke, then the car died. When it rains, it pours.

126 **When pigs fly**
Never going to happen.
They'll apologise when pigs fly.

127 **You can't have your cake and eat it**
You can't have two good things that don't go together.
You want the money and the free time? You can't have your cake and eat it.

128 **You reap what you sow**
You get the results of your own actions.
He was rude to everyone for years, and you reap what you sow.

129 **Your comfort zone**
The situations you find easy because you already know them.
Nothing grows inside your comfort zone.

SIMILES 31

1 **Like a broken record**
Saying the same thing over and over.
I sound like a broken record, but please lock the door.

2 **Like a bull in a china shop**
Clumsy and careless with delicate things.
He came in like a bull in a china shop.

3 **Like a deer in the headlights**
Frozen, with no idea what to do.
When they asked him a question he looked like a deer in the headlights.

4 **Like a fish out of water**
Uncomfortable somewhere new or unfamiliar.
At my first rugby match I felt like a fish out of water.

5 **As blind as a bat**
Can hardly see anything.
Without my glasses I'm as blind as a bat.

6 **As busy as a bee**
Working non-stop.
He's been as busy as a bee since the baby arrived.

7 **As clear as mud**
Not clear at all.
His explanation was as clear as mud.

8 **As cool as a cucumber**
Completely calm when other people would panic.
She was as cool as a cucumber in the interview.

9 **As dry as a bone**
Completely dry.
The garden is as dry as a bone.

10 **As easy as pie**
Very easy once you know how.
After the second time it's as easy as pie.

11 **Eat like a horse**
Eat a huge amount.
He's skinny, but he eats like a horse.

12 **Fight like cat and dog**
Argue constantly.
Those two fight like cat and dog, then go for coffee.

13 **As fit as a fiddle**
In excellent health.
At seventy he's still as fit as a fiddle.

14 **Go down like a lead balloon**
Be received really badly.
My joke went down like a lead balloon.

15 **As good as gold**
Very well behaved.
He sat as good as gold through the concert.

16 **As happy as Larry**
Perfectly content with very little.
Give him a sandwich and he's as happy as Larry.

17 **Like herding cats**
Impossible to organise.
Teaching them on a Friday is like herding cats.

18 **As light as a feather**
Weighing almost nothing.
Pick it up, it's as light as a feather.

19 **As mad as a hatter**
Completely crazy, in a harmless funny way.
Her uncle is as mad as a hatter and we love him for it.

20 **As old as the hills**
Extremely old, and everyone has heard it before.
That joke is as old as the hills.

21 **As quiet as a mouse**
Making no sound at all.
She sat as quiet as a mouse at the back.

22 **As right as rain**
Perfectly fine again after feeling bad.
A cup of tea and I'll be as right as rain.

23 **Run around like a headless chicken**
Rush about in a panic with no plan.
He spent the morning running around like a headless chicken.

24 **As sick as a dog**
Very ill indeed.
I was as sick as a dog all weekend.

25 **Sleep like a log**
Sleep deeply and never move.
I walked all day and slept like a log.

26 **Spread like wildfire**
Travel incredibly fast, usually news.
The rumour spread like wildfire.

27 **As stubborn as a mule**
Refusing to change your mind.
Don't argue with him, he's as stubborn as a mule.

28 **Like talking to a brick wall**
A completely pointless conversation.
Asking him to listen is like talking to a brick wall.

29 **Like two peas in a pod**
Two people who are very alike.
Those two are like two peas in a pod.

30 **Like watching paint dry**
Unbelievably boring.
That meeting was like watching paint dry.

31 **As white as a sheet**
Pale with shock or fear.
She read the message and went as white as a sheet.